

SIGMA

Technology & Product Management club

PLACEMENT PREPARATION

Summer Placements – Product Management

2019 Edition

Microsoft

Designation: Program Manager Intern

Job Description: As the in-house advocate for the millions of people worldwide who use Microsoft products, you drive the technical vision, design, implementation and market success of next-generation software solutions.

As the CEO of your product components, some of the questions which you would be addressing through your role are:

• What customer problem I am addressing?

• What product solution do I craft to address this gap?

• How do I deliver the best customer experience possible?

• Does the product solution meet the business need (revenue, brand, etc.)?

• How do I take the product from conceptualization to launch?

• How do I work with marketing, and various sales channels to drive adoption?

Roles & Responsibilities:

The role entails the following three distinct aspects:

Defining and executing product strategy and roadmap: Defining who the product is for, identifying the fundamental problem that we are solving, understanding the competition, and our core positioning with respect to the competition, identifying our approach to the market and partnerships.

Building the Product: Lots of white boarding, storyboarding, sketching and designing, iterating with engineering on trade-offs between priority/timelines/capabilities, partnering across teams in Microsoft to deliver the solution, performing usability studies, planning versions, legal, marketing, monetization plans etc.

Connecting with the customer: Evangelizing the product through customer connect, being the 'face' of the product, experimentation and data analysis, iterating on feedback and learnings.

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + Group Activity + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 10

Experiences

1) **Name : Tirtha Tushar Pandey**

   Workex : 35 months, Software Engineer, Amadeus

   Education Background : Information Technology from NIT Durgapur 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Product Strategy

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans : In the Group Activity we had a product design question for WhatsApp for enterprises. We had 10 mins to think individually on the solution. Then we had to discuss our solutions and finally converge to a single solution. I clearly established my objective, followed the CIRCLES approach to solve the problem and drew mocks. There were very few inputs from the moderator. I listed the potential segments, reasoned out the most attractive segment to target and built features on top of that. The moderator put forward some additional questions such as pricing of the product and maintenance.

I just had one round of interview of around 20 mins. I was asked mainly product design questions. No resume questions or guesstimates were asked.

Interviewer - Tell me about yourself?

I talked about my love for travelling.

Interviewer - Tell me a real-world problem you would like to solve?

I targeted poverty reduction through an app in the agriculture sector on the lines of Microsoft's FarmBeats. I was asked to design a dashboard for FarmBeats. This basically became a product design question

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : Having a tech background is certainly a plus but not necessary.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Decode & Conquer, Cracking the PM interview, Sigma/PlaceCom prep material.

We did the prep in a group of 5. We critiqued a lot of products, discussed the things we liked and the things we would like to improve. We did just a preliminary research on Microsoft products which included its main features and competitors. We simulated interviews and practiced product design and guesstimates through this one on one approach.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Microsoft's PM workshop is really important. Do attend it and interact with the team. I was told that the points I made during the workshop was central to me getting a hotlist.

2) **Name : Puja Dubey**

Workex : 48 months, Software Engineer, TCS

Education Background : Electrical Engineering from BIT Mesra 2011-15

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans : In the Group Activity we had a product design question for WhatsApp for education. We had to initially think individually on the solution. The moderator would come to us from time to time, look at our approach and make some suggestions. He was quite particular about the segment we were targeting with the product. It was important to narrow down on a single segment such as teachers, parents, high school students, etc. I followed a structured approach to solve the problem, drew mocks and provided metrics to evaluate the success of the product. After about 10 mins, everyone participating in the Group Activity discussed their view points. The moderator asked everybody to pitch their ideas in 30 seconds at the end.

I had 2 rounds of interviews of 30 mins each, both were technical. Even the HR questions were swiftly directed towards the technical side.

Interviewer - Tell me about yourself in terms of the work that excites you.

Interviewer - What is one product you would like to build?

I am inclined towards social work and suggested an app to connect restaurants with excess food to NGOs working towards eradicating hunger. This then became a standard product design question.

Interviewer - What do you want to do in life?

I told the interviewer my aspirations to contribute in the education sector and suggested an app for the rural areas. This again became a product design question.

Interviewer - Any question you have for us?

I had read many articles and was informed about the latest happenings at Microsoft. The interviewers were impressed by my questions.

Interviewer - What excites you about Microsoft?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : Having a tech background is certainly a plus but not necessary.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Decode & Conquer, Cracking the PM interview, Sigma/PlaceCom prep material.

Critiqued a lot of products, both general and Microsoft specific. Practiced simple cases and guesstimates, not at the level of the consulting folks. We did the prep in a group of 3. We used to solve questions individually and then discuss. This was a great approach as we were able to get a lot of new ideas and insights from each other.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Prepare from the beginning, form a group to study and remain focussed. Internalise the thought process to solving product design questions.

3) Name : Sakshi Goyal

Workex : 24 months, Product Engineer, SLK Softwares

Education Background : B. Tech in Computer Science from LNMIIT, Jaipur

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, App Critique

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans : My GD topic was to design WhatsApp for Enterprises. We were given the topic and were asked to work on it individually. The moderator then came to everyone and asked about the approach and suggested changes or asked to work on a particular use case.

I had one round of interview of about 30 mins. The interview started with a basic tell me about yourself question. Then I was asked what my motivation for going for a Product Management role was. After that I was asked to give three things that I liked and disliked about a technical product. After this, the questions were dependent on the answers that I gave. For the things that I dislike about the product, I was asked how I would change that, and based on my responses I was asked to elaborate on some use cases for particular changes.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : No. But some technical knowledge is required.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : The books Cracking the PM Interview and Decode and Conquer helped develop my approach for solving case based or product improvements questions. Apart from that, one should be prepared for basic HR and resume based questions.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : I felt that in GD, they looked for a structured approach for problem solving and not the solution itself. Same is the case with the interviews, the solutions that you propose don't have to be something unusual, but they should come out of a structured process and should be backed up by solid reasons.

4) **Name : Ridhima Gupta**

Workex : 20 months, Devops & Cloud Engineer, SapientRazorfish

Education Background : B.Tech-CSE, Amity University, Noida

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Product Strategy

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans : The GD round was conducted for approximately 30 mins, 4 candidates in a group, 1 panellist. The topic given was WhatsApp for students. Each candidate was asked to sit separately and design the product in a structured manner. The panelist visited each candidate individually to check on their approach. After 15 mins, each candidate had approximately 1 min to pitch their product and approach. Once everyone had pitched, all 4 candidates were asked to discuss the features suggested and come up with the final product.

The interviews consisted of mainly Prod designs and some HR questions. They were least interested in guesstimates.

Interview Round 1: (40 mins), 1 panellist

Interviewer - What are you most passionate about? A coding complexity question (I had mentioned coding as a passion).

Interviewer - Design a product to solve a problem in sports (Sports is another passion I mentioned).

Interviewer - Show structured approach in product design, be clear with what the product is and what technologies would be used in the background.

Interviewer - Interview Round 2: (15 mins), 1 panellist

Interviewer - Why Microsoft? What problem in the world is Microsoft uniquely positioned to solve? Some questions on my workex. Why did you use AWS in your project and not Azure?

My suggestion:

1. Always Think aloud and don't forget GTM strategies.
2. Be structured in your approach
3. Carry pen and paper and copies of your resumes
4. Be thorough with you resume
5. Stay calm and confident

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : Relevant work experience is not necessary but it surely gives an edge.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Thoroughly read cracking the PM interview. Read about latest technologies and company related news. Have an idea about the company's future goals and vision. Also, look at the biggest competitors and be ready to answer how you can improve existing products/services.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Remain calm. Think aloud and be structured in your approach. Ask any clarifying questions that come to your mind. Most importantly, be confident!

5) Name : Divyansh Agarwal

Workex : 8 months, Market Analyst, Futures First

18 months, Product & Business Head, Toppers Notes

Education Background : B.Tech Metallurgical Engineering, MNIT Jaipur

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Metrics, System Design

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans : The hiring process consisted on Group Discussion (GD) round (20 minutes average) followed by multiple interview rounds of 20 minutes each.

The GD round is fundamentally different for Microsoft. A group of candidates are given a PM case study which they are required to submit in writing. The invigilator discusses individually with each candidate about the case. The candidates are expected to approach the problem in a structural manner stating with problem statement, Goals/Non-Goals, Customer Segmentation, Feature addition and Metrics to be measured.

The first interview round was a technical round. It involved questions based on prior work experience. The candidate was asked about various technologies that were used in previous organization. The candidate was asked few questions on Microsoft's products like OneNote and HoloLens.

The 2nd round was mostly technical with few soft-skill questions. I was asked basic computer science and coding questions like

- Concept of stack, Queue, heap
- Basic understanding of servers
- What is time complexity?
- Name few sorting algorithms and their time complexity
- Write a sorting algorithm to invert to sort the characters of an string

I was also asked few soft-skill questions about leadership and role of a product manager.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : I don't think so.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : I prepared for the case study and Guesstimate type questions.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : My suggestion would be to get familiar with the latest technological trends and popular apps. Knowledge of basic Computer Science concepts, Product Management, and algorithms like searching and sorting are also helpful.

6) Name : Praharshitha KV

Workex : 47 months, Software Engineer, Cipher Cloud

Education Background : CSE from BITS-Hyderabad 2011-15

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, App Critique

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans : We had a task based GD, topic - Design WhatsApp for enterprises. 10-15 mins. Use existing features to help enterprises. There were a few counter questions such as

- What's stopping WhatsApp to be used by enterprises?
- Tell strengths and weaknesses of WhatsApp.

There 2 rounds of interviews each lasting close to an hour.

R1 : What are you passionate about and what are you planning to do it? Healthcare. Challenges and ethics involved.

R2 : Hobbies, design round - trekking, google photos - what is missing, 3 good and bad things.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : Nope. 2-3 people got in without such background.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : John C Lewis and Cracking the PM interview. Read about MSFT products and what are they planning to get into. Source : Google news.

Group preparation for 10 days with 2 other people.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Remain calm, better to be clear and confident, don't mix sentences.

They like clarity of thought, don't get stressed if your interview goes on for more than an hour. Read from TechCrunch, wired.com, mint (M&A)

Practice lots of Prod Design questions. They were asking about non-Microsoft products. Discussion about Pharma industry was an add-on. Be clear on an industry you like and know everything about it.

7) **Name: Ankit Bamnote**

Workex: 23 months, Executive Engineer, Siemens Ltd

Education Background: B.Tech (E&Tc) COE Pune

PM Topics Covered: Product Design

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: We had a product based GD, it was technically not a GD. A problem was given to the group and we had to work on that individually. We were tasked with designing WhatsApp for students.

I had 1 interview of 45 minutes. A couple of simple HR questions such as why PM and why Microsoft. After that, completely technical interview which included discussions on my previous projects/products, analysis of a certain MS product. There were no guesstimates or cases.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans: Not necessarily. However, prior work ex in Software/product domain will boost your chances.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans: Sigma/PlaceCom prep material. Tried to analyse and study various apps and desktop software products.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans: Be clear about why you want to get into PM. Study product development cycle thoroughly. During GD, cover all the steps right from Identifying customer base to revenue streams.

Amazon

Designation: Product Management Intern

Job Description: Intern must be customer obsessed and possess strong analytical skills, exceptional communication abilities and a strategic mind-set. Candidate must be a team player and bring experience working with cross-functional teams. Prior experience in consumer internet space or in the financial services or payments space is preferred.

This role is responsible for working with the worldwide Amazon team to formulate recommendations on new business initiatives and partnering with operations, technology teams, and product development teams to implement these recommendations. As a product manager, you will develop long-term strategies to offer customer-centric features and programs, and ensure quality onsite customer experience and overall service. The ideal candidate will be enthusiastic about managing challenging, lengthy projects across multiple teams and locations. He or she will be comfortable marshalling large amounts of data to make decisions and build business cases. We are looking for a Product Manager who shares Amazon's passion for the customer— someone who understands the importance of compelling features and functionalities in driving great customer experience.

Focus and deliverables

• Identify and prioritize the most immediate improvement opportunities.

• Benchmark competitive experiences across the customer value chain, and define and implement a roadmap of improvements that ensure Amazon leadership for each of these.

• Create and implement a roadmap that ensures leadership in customer experience in each business category.

Roles and Responsibilities

• Define and drive a world-class customer experience. Create alignment for the product vision. Translate the customer experience into a logically sequenced and optimized product roadmap.

• Partner with global category leaders to establish selection strategy of brands and products, and work with global vendors to add selection to the global catalogue.

• Maintain a product and feature roadmap and manage prioritization and trade-offs among customer experience, site performance and operational support load.

• Proactively identify and resolve strategic issues that may impair the team’s ability to meet strategic, financial, and technical goals. Lead cross-functionally to ensure we implement the business vision efficiently.

• Own ongoing and continuous improvement of the customer experience and defect reduction for all products.

• Prepare business cases for category-specific initiatives targeted at improving category experience and partner with the appropriate cross-functional teams to deliver them.

Selection Process: Online simulation assessment + Resume shortlisting + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 2

Experiences

1) **Name : Udita Prajapati**

Workex : 33 months, Software Engineer, SAP

Education Background : CSE, NIT Patna 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Product Strategy, Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: I had only 1 round of interview of more than an hour with 2 panellists.

Interviewer- Tell me about yourself, your favourite product, improvements suggested and what you like

He wanted to gauge my interest in product management. I talked about the UBER app.

Interviewer - Let's say you own a car and you wish to pool with people while commuting to the office. Design an app while making sure you don't feel like a driver.

I designed an app on the lines of QuickRide. I started with the value proposition, why people would use it and designed a mock up for driver and user. Next I worked on the socialising aspect, rating system needed, the process of the driver and user selecting each other and users connecting to people with similar interests/careers.

Interviewer - Alexa has a lot of skills. We are thinking about creating a skill around spirituality. How can you cater to religious users? You're given a market and suggest features people would like? How will you collect needs of the customers?

I talked about meditation, guided yoga being the immediate need for users. I prioritised the user segment being targeted and features being rolled out in the initial versions.

Interviewer - Let's say you're a subject matter expert for a topic, create a service to share my knowledge. How'd you apply ML and AI to this? How'd you monetize it? Suppose we wish to have this service in a corporate setup for ramp up of employees. What changes do you suggest?

After these technical questions there were a string of HR questions.

Interviewer - How'd you demonstrate bias for action in your work experience? State the best example. (Amazon's 14 leadership principles)

Interviewer - What are the reasons for your consistent performance?

Interviewer - Why not consulting? Are you comfortable working in ambiguous situations and seeking help from others?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : I am from CSE background with 3 years of workex. I think it matters.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : John C Lewis and Cracking the PM interview. Be updated about the latest technologies, their applications, have a good understanding of design and don't limit yourself to software applications. They can ask about physical products too. I did solo preparation with focus and discipline.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Remain calm. Always think aloud. Use a pen and paper (carry it), be structured. The problem might appear overwhelming at first, but ask questions. Interviewers are there to guide you. Be thorough with your workex and resume.

2) Name : Zubin Sheth

Workex : 48 months, Investment Banking Associate, Goldman Sachs

Education Background : BE-CSE, Jadavpur University, 2011-15

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: I had 2 rounds of interviews, lasting a total of 45 mins.

Round 1

- Tell me about yourself.
- Tell me about your previous role.
- You have some Prod Man experience, what all did you manage?
- How did you ensure collaboration with engineering teams who did not report to you?
- How often would you meet you stakeholders and how will you set up meetings and go about it?

- What all tools have you used yet?
- Who drives the business requirement or changes in product?
- How do you ensure business requirement is met versus internal priority of the team for that product?
- What if business asks you to deliver something ASAP?

Round 2

- Suppose amazon furniture page has only 1 chair and nothing else to be sold and fkart also has the exact same chair and that too only 1 product on their website. What would you do to ensure customer buys from amazon?
- Tell us 1 problem with any of the amazon products or services and how would you go about solving it?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : I did have relevant work experience in Product Management

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : I didn't do any Prod Man specific prep.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Remain calm and be confident.

Sprinklr

Designation: Summer Intern

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 7

Experiences

1) **Name : Akshay Khairkar**

Workex : 24 months, Software Engineer, JP Morgan Chase

Education Background : B.Tech IT - VJTI, Mumbai

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Product Strategy, Behavioral, Root Cause Analysis

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: The hiring process consisted of 3 rounds. First 2 rounds, each of 45 mins were case based where the interviewee was given a problem statement and was expected to come up with an end to end product design. The last round being a nominal HR interview consisted of basic sanity check HR questions.

Round 1 – 2 interviewers P1 & P2

P1 – Questions asked related to work experience as mentioned in the resume

P2 – Questions related to sorting, their efficiencies and what could be the worst case of sorting 10 beads numbered 1 to 10

Ans – Keep throwing beads into the air till the time they fall down in a sorted manner

P1 – Case – Design a music player for elderly people

P2 – Your company produces a wooden frame which is already available in the market at a cheaper price. What can be the reason for your company to produce these frames by yourself?

P1 – Your boss has suggested a design change and your team has also come up with a different design change. Given that you can only implement one out of it, how will you go about selecting the right change?

P2 – How important do you think a product design should align with company's mission and vision. Can you back it up with an example?

P1 – MakeMyTrip has recently seen a surge in the no. of users on its website. Still the profit of the company is going down. What can be the possible reasons?

Round 2 – 1 interviewer

- Questions related to workexp were asked in detail. What is automation and how it is disrupting the IT industry?

- Which is your favourite product?

- What is one thing that you would like to improve about this product?

- What would be the metrics you would consider to evaluate the performance of your feature?

- You are a Product Manager and have to implement 5 features out of the 10 identified features. How will you prioritize what all features to implement and how would you measure their performance?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : As per the job description, no specific work experience criteria was specified. However prior experience in product development definitely gives an upper edge over other candidates. Also, the interviewers mostly try to evaluate how loud and far a candidate can think and what all scenarios s(he) brings into considerations.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Book – Cracking the PM Interview. It's advised that you go through this book thoroughly and learn all the frameworks and concepts for designing a product, market entry of a product, etc. Self-study would suffice but won't be helpful in the long run. Forming a group of 3-4 dedicated PM enthusiasts would sky rocket your preparation.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Be thorough with each and every point in the resume. Keep your mind calm. Just don't try to force fit every framework and concepts that you have learned. Common sense can make wonders sometimes 😊

2) Name : Ayush Tayal

Workex : 48 months, Automation Engineer, Qualcomm

Education Background : BTech - ECE, DTU 2011-15

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: The interviews consisted of 2 technical interviews lasting 20 mins each and an HR round of 10 mins.

Round 1

- Tell me about yourself
- Design a camera for elderly people
- Design a music system for elderly people
- Design a blog like WordPress, would you do it in-house or outsource it.
- General overview of work experience

Answered the Design Questions Based on CIRCLES framework and defended each answer with reasoning and justification.

Round 2

- Asked about work experience in Qualcomm
- Asked to explain Resume points on Work experience
- Major responsibilities handled
- Why do you want to join Sprinklr?
- Why Product Management?
- Give me one reason why I should not hire you

Round 3 - Discussed about hometown, workplace and other basic HR questions.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : It is good to have, but do not think it's a deciding factor.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Decode and Conquer and Cracking the PM interview. Formed case prep groups of 4 and discussed D&C cases. Solved online guesstimates as well.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Stay focussed and keep frequently meeting the case group to discuss cases. Better if some time is spent alone on solving cases and discussing in teams later to get varied views. Have a product you like/dislike along with features/improvements.

3) Name : Abhishek Tawania

Workex : 34 months, Associate, JP Morgan Chase

Education Background : BTech - CSE, VIT 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Execution, Root Cause Analysis

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: I had 2 rounds of technical interviews of 20 mins each and an HR round of 5 mins. My interview questions were based on my previous work experience. Most questions were based on how to manage a product.

- Why cloud or physical servers?
- How to identify if there is low adoption for your product?
- How to prove that the reason for low adoption is correct?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : No. I don't think so.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : I had clarity on what the role of a Product Manager is. I also made sure to read about the working of the company.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Basic common sense helps. Take your time when asked questions. Do not be in a hurry during the interviews and continuously work with the interviewer to solve the questions and the situations.

AppDynamics

Designation: Product Manager Intern

Job Description: You'll nurture a piece of our product portfolio and be part of our team that is fostering its growth. As a Senior Product Manager, your role will be to understand the needs of our enterprise customers and guide and coordinate a team of designers and engineers to deliver a product that has a transformative impact for those customers. You will have the opportunity – and the challenge – to think deeply about the direction of our product, and to work with a team to see it come alive. In this role, you will:

• Own and guide the product vision and strategy for critical parts of our product portfolio

• Develop empathy for our customers and field teams so that you understand our customers and their needs. You will articulate those needs within AppDynamics and lead product initiatives that build solutions tailored to meet those needs as they evolve

• Collaborate with engineering, sales and design to solve customer problems and motivate our teams to ship quality product in a sustainable, enjoyable team environment

• Achieve a balance between the various demands of the organization and its customers as you prioritize your backlog

• Educate internal groups and customers about your roadmap in order to communicate direction and gather feedback

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 1

Experiences

1) **Name : Shubhankar Yash**

Workex : 29 months, Software Development Engineer, Flipkart

Education Background : BE-EEE, BITS Pilani, 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: 2 rounds of interviews each lasting around 30 minutes. The first interview round had 2 panellists – a Product Manager and a member of senior leadership.

- They started off with a case question about Microsoft Excel and Google Sheets. They gave me several decisions that each party made and asked me how this would impact the other. I also had to imagine I was part of the

other firm, decide which metrics I would you look at and what decisions I would take to react.
- They further asked how each app i.e. Excel and Sheets functioned in the respective company's ecosystem of apps.
- I was asked how it was ensured at Flipkart that people get expertise in different domains thus reducing the company's dependency on them.
- I was asked about my strengths and weaknesses
- I was asked why I wanted to join AppDynamics. I talked about the other application monitoring softwares/platforms I had used at Flipkart, the pain points the developers, PMs and business folks faced and how AppDynamics is a step ahead.

The second round of interview again had 2 panellists – an Engineering Manager and a UX Designer.

- I was asked about my start-up. I was asked to apply the concepts learnt in the strategy courses to analyse whether the start-up had potential.
- I was asked about user experience. What do you mean by it? I explained it using examples. About how good user experience would vary depending on the situation the user is in – i.e. optimized image loading in 2G networks, vernacular support for tier 3 cities, etc.
- I was asked the work I was most proud of in terms of user experience. What pain points did it solve? Which metrics were looked at to deduce the engineering, user experience and business success?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : Yes. Non-tech people weren't shortlisted.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Decode & Conquer, Cracking the PM interview, Sigma/PlaceCom prep material. We did the prep in a group of 4. We critiqued a lot of apps, discussed the things we liked and the things we would like to improve. We generally divided apps among the people, conducted research individually and then discussed the findings with the group. We solved product design and guesstimates individually in groups of 2 and then discussed our solutions with each other to get each other's perspectives.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Do look at company specific details so that you can ask intelligent questions to the panel. This would also help you answer the "why you want to join the company". Your desire to join the company should be clearly visible in your answers.

VMWare

Designation: Product Manager Intern

Job Description:

• Strategize, drive, and bring assigned product lines to market with thorough analysis and information on the technical relationship between VMware products and services.

• Work cross functionally with other business units including Engineering, Sales, and Product Marketing through entire product development lifecycle from requirement gathering through deployment.

• Utilize professional concepts to resolve complex issues in creative and effective ways. Exercise independent judgment in selecting methods, techniques and evaluation criteria for obtaining results.

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + GD + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 3

Experiences

1) **Name : Aravindth Sudthan B**

Workex : 30 months, Network & Automation Orchestrator, AppViewX

18 months, MD, Textile Firm

Education Background : BTech, IIT Bombay, 2011-15

PM Topics Covered: Product Strategy

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: The group discussion comprised 10 candidates. Each candidate was asked to select a topic on technology, do a SWOT analysis, and comment on future trends with 1 minute to think and about 2 minutes to talk. The students took turns to talk. I talked about integrating the network automation industry and telecom industry and linked it with the VMWare product, VSphere extending to the product's lifecycle and how the product should evolve.

I had one interview round of 40 mins. I was asked only one question – Strategy based. Two companies are ready to supply water. Given the quantity and other specifications same, how can you position one of them better than the other. I suggested to add the source of the water on the label to signal better taste and quality thus creating the differentiation.

The panel asked me to interview them. My questions were VMWare specific (I had worked on the products of VMWare during my work) Some of the questions I asked the panel were:

- Why hasn't the company expanded for last 5 years?
- What is its upcoming M&A? (This followed from the answer by the panelist to the previous question)
- OpenStack has been the leader in tools for packaging the product. VMWare hasn't improved in this sphere. What is the plan on this front?
- How many agile cycles are taken to release the product?
- Why VSphere performs DNS based segregation? Within a subnet, how the addresses are resolved?
- What is the hierarchy of Source Code Management?
- Why is the VMWare licensing based on product and not modules – module-based licensing yields high long stream revenue.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : I don't think it is necessary, but my interview was totally based on the VMWare products I used during my work experience.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Nothing specific for Prod Man.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Be very strong on the concepts pertaining to work experience. Read about technology, latest trends, its evolution. Learn about the products and the outlook of the company you're interviewing for.

2) Name : Tejal Kamble

Workex : 26 months, Big Data Consultant, Capegemini

14 months, Micro-market Manager, Oyo

Education Background : BTech+MTech, IIT Kharagpur, 2009-14

PM Topics Covered: Product Strategy

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: The group discussion comprised 10 candidates. Each candidate was asked to select a topic on technology, do a SWOT analysis, and comment on future trends with 1 minute to think and about 2 minutes to talk. The students took turns to talk. I talked about Role of Career Counselling & Development Services.

I had one interview round of 30 minutes. There were two panellists from R&D and HR. I was asked predominantly resume based questions. I was asked to show the calculations on how I arrived at the numerical values for performance measures in the resume. Based on my projects in IOT, Big Data, Market research, Dashboards with Tableau further questions were asked. Also, the panellists asked me to design a framework to evaluate the performance of the start-ups as they were looking for candidates with start-up knowledge and the role involved assessing start-ups. And then questions like why VMWare and knowledge about products of VMWare were asked.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : My whole interview was based on my work experience and they looked for candidates with knowledge in technology and startups, so I think relevant work experience is important.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Solved cases and guesstimates in group of three, read John C Lewis and Cracking the PM interview.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Know the Tech Space, be thorough with your resume, know about the company and its products.

3) Name : Shubhankar Yash

Workex : 29 months, Software Development Engineer, Flipkart

Education Background : BE-EEE, BITS Pilani, 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: In the group discussion, we were given the topic of Digital India – Leader or Follower? There were 8 people in the GD, we were divided into 2 groups, and each group had to take a side and debate. This was a pretty orderly discussion and the moderator was keen to know the viewpoints of everyone.

The interview consisted a panel of 3 and lasted around 15 mins. There weren't any technical questions i.e. no product design, cases or guesstimates. There were mainly HR and resume questions. I was asked about my time at Flipkart – interesting projects that I worked on and challenges that I faced. They also asked

about the start-up that I had co-founded. In the end I was asked whether I had any questions for them.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : All the people who received offers had worked in the tech space and had questions related to their work experience. So, I think it matters.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Decode & Conquer, Cracking the PM interview, Sigma/PlaceCom prep material.

We did the prep in a group of 4. We critiqued a lot of apps, discussed the things we liked and the things we would like to improve. We generally divided apps among the people, conducted research individually and then discussed the findings with the group. We solved product design and guesstimates individually in groups of 2 and then discussed our solutions with each other to get each other's perspectives.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Do look at company specific details so that you can ask intelligent questions to the panel.

United Health Group

Designation: Product Intern

Job Description:

This position would give the selected individual an opportunity to work on a live customer project in the healthcare space. The selected individual would be the part of a team that is involved in defining a solution and executing the same for one of our key stakeholders.

- Work with the business to identify, analyze, document the business, recommending business priorities, and advising business on options, risks, and solutions.
- Data analysis understand, interpret, validate, manipulate data using excel and other tools, and present conclusions and recommendations.
- Qualitative analysis using business management concepts and strategy definition.

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + GD + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 3

Experiences

1) **Name : Nupur Sahu**

Workex : 49 months, Product Application Engineer, Xilinx Inc

Education Background : BTech-ECE, NIT Rourkela, 2011-15

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, System Design, Product Execution, App Critique

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: We had a group discussion on “Microsoft vs Google” which consisted of 10 candidates and lasted 15 minutes. I had 3 rounds of interviews, each lasting 25 mins.

The first round was a technical round. The questions were based on work experience and were related to the software application that I worked on in previous company. Below are few questions that were asked:

- Explain the use case of the application.
- Suggest a few feature improvements for the application.
- What are the technologies used to build the application?

The second round was also technical in nature. The questions were feature improvement questions in relation to existing applications. I was asked question on two applications which are as follows:

- Addition of new features to cab aggregator apps like Uber and Ola

- Addition of new features to an agile project management application (It was one of the applications that I was familiar with)

The final round focused on my long-term and short-term goals. The discussion was mostly on product management. Few situation-based questions that I was expected to tackle as a product manager were also asked.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : I did have prior software development experience. So, I think it mattered.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : I prepared for technology, feature-addition/improvement and guestimate type questions. “Cracking the PM interview” and “Decode and Conquer” are the two suggested books for everyone looking to land a PM role.

2) Name : Kunusoth Haripriya

Workex : 35 months, Software Engineer, Micro Focus

Education Background : BTech-CSE, NIT Rourkela, 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Behavioral

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: We had a group discussion on “Current state of Indian Economy” which consisted of 8 candidates and lasted 20 minutes. I had 5 rounds of interviews. The first one was 30 mins, the second 50 mins and the remaining 15 mins each.

The first round was a technical round. It involved questions based on my work experience. The questions were related to different projects that I worked on in my previous company.

The second round was mostly a technical round with few soft-skill questions. I was asked app-based questions. I was asked to come up three new features for WhatsApp and justify their addition. In addition to it, I was also asked to explain my interest in UnitedHealth Group. I was asked a few questions on product management like “What is Product Management?” and “What is the role of a Product Manager?”

After the first 2 rounds, I faced 3 more rounds of which one was a stress interview. The three interviews focused on soft skills. The questions were mainly situation-based questions that I was expected to face as a product manager. Few questions involved discussions around my PORs.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : My prior experience certainly helped me during my interview.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : I prepared for guesstimates and PM case study-based questions.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Project confidence while answering during the interview. Resume preparation is also essential as a significant portion of interview questions were related to work experience.

3) Name : Biswaranjan Jena

Workex : 35 months, Platform & Performance Engineer, Target

Education Background : BTech-Mining, IIT Kharagpur, 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, Product Execution, App Critique

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: We had a group discussion on “Cow Vigilante Violence in India” which consisted of 10 candidates and lasted 10 minutes. I had 2 rounds of interviews of 45 mins each.

The first round was technical in nature. I was asked questions based on prior work experience. I was asked questions on my role, tech-skills and various projects that I worked on in the previous organization. In addition to it, I was also asked questions based on feature improvement in existing apps. Below is the list for the same:

- Compare Gmail and Outlook
- Suggest a new feature for Gmail and justify the use-case

The second round was also technical in nature. I was asked a few more feature improvement questions. Below is the list for the same:

- Suggest 3 new features for Quora and justify their use-case
- Suggest and justify a feature that should be dropped from Quora
- Suggest a new feature for an agile project management software (It was one of the softwares that I was familiar with)

In addition to it, the candidate was asked few questions on product management which are as follows:

- What is the role of product manager?
- What is Software Development Life Cycle?
- What is the agile approach of software development?
- Compare the water-flow method of product development with the agile approach.

Few situation-based and soft-skill based questions were also asked. Below is the list for the same:

- How would you deal with situation where you have to convince multiple stakeholders about a new feature addition that might affect their product?
- How would you handle a situation where the business requirement is vague, and the engineering team is in need of new projects?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : My prior experience certainly helped me during my interview.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : I prepared for guesstimates and PM Case studies.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : My suggestion would be to get familiar with various applications like Cab aggregator apps, Social Media apps, Chat apps, Email apps, Online travel apps, Unorganized service aggregator apps
etc. Furthermore, basic understanding of product management is also helpful.

OLX

Designation: Product Management Intern

Job Description:

As a Product Management Intern, you will work on one or more live projects for OLX as part of a cross-functional team. You will be aligned to a Product manager during your internship and will work closely with him or her on the following aspects during the internship:

- Develop the strategy for building / launching a new feature or product for OLX basis data insights, user research, user feedback, market research & new technology developments
- Identify use cases and user journeys for each feature and work closely with the User Experience Design team that develops wireframes & prototypes to define the user experience
- Participate in user research and user testing associated with the feature / product
- Build detailed feature / product requirements & communicate to all key stakeholders across functions and with global teams
- Translate the product requirements into crisp user stories for the Engineering team
- Work closely with the User Experience Design and Engineering team during the development sprint cycles and closely track progress
- Define and measure success metrics for each feature / product. If the feature is launched, drive the post-launch analysis

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 2

Experiences

1) **Name : Sushil Barnwal**

Workex : 36 months, Software Engineer, Visa

Education Background : Bachelors in Information Technology, VIT, 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Root Cause Analysis, Guesstimates

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: I had only one round of interview of about 45 minutes. I was asked the following questions

- About myself and then some follow up questions.
- One case: A printer company recently faced with decrease in its profitability, what could be the reasons (given everything was constant i.e. nothing changed in its internal and external factors). The solution was that they were scaling up in the company.

- A guesstimate of the number of windows in NY City. Was asked 3 ways to solve this.
- What will you do if you have 200 crore in your account?
- Some hobbies related questions.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : No, not really. I had work experience in automotive industry and having job role of Quality Auditor.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Solved cases and guestimates. I did not prepare specifically for Prod Man as I was looking for other options.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Prepare cases and guestimates and for Prod Man, go through the available materials shared by Sigma & PlaceCom.

2) Name : Ashwani Kumar

Workex : 23 months, Engineer, Larsen & Toubro

Education Background : BTech-EEE, NIT Puducherry, 2013-17

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, App Critique

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: I had only one round of interview of about 35 minutes. Product design questions were not asked. I was asked the following questions

- Why would you like to work for OLX? I aligned my answer with their values (unless it is really your dream job, don't say so because they will easily know)
- What are your strengths and weaknesses?
- One attribute of yours that you would like to improve?
- No. of windows in the New York City?
- No. of lifts in a 100*100 feet building with 20 floors?

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : No, not really. I did not have any software experience.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Resources provided by the Placement committee were enough for the preparation. Other than that, memorize the basic facts like the population of New Delhi, Mumbai, New York, India, U.S., India's age-wise population break-up, average number of men, women, and children in a city and village, etc.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Being honest helped in the interview. The interview was a stress interview, the interviewer wanted to test whether I was telling the truth. He asked follow-up questions until he was satisfied. For the guestimates, confirm every assumption, ask questions, and clarify any doubts. Moreover, the interviewers were very helpful during guestimates and provided all the required information whenever required.

Adobe

Designation: Product Manager Intern

Job Description:

- Primary and secondary research to identify user needs and emerging trends
- Understanding competitive, partner landscape and generating actionable insights
- You will pitch and validate new product ideas for internal and external partners
- Contributing to Product, Go to Market vision and strategy
- Building requirement documents and specs, detailing out user journey, use cases.
- Collaborate with Design and Engineering to create proof of concept, actual implementation

Selection Process: Resume shortlisting + Interview

Number of candidates selected: 3

Experiences

1) **Name : Chris Macman**

Workex : 36 months, Software Engineer, Visa

Education Background : Bachelors in Information Technology, VIT, 2012-16

PM Topics Covered: Product Design, App Critique, Guesstimates

Q1. What sort of questions were asked in the hiring process?

Ans: I had 2 rounds of interviews and was asked resume, product design questions and guesstimates. The following questions were asked:

- I had a start-up in college, they asked about it and pushed me to answer how that could be made into a product
- I was asked about my favourite app and what feature I would add to it.
- I worked for a start-up that worked in the e-learning space. They asked how I can make it better. I was also asked a guesstimate around the customer base of the product.

Q2. Is relevant work experience necessary?

Ans : I don't think it was required in the JD, but it definitely strengthens your resume.

Q3. How did you go about preparing for the Prod Man interviews?

Ans : Decode & Conquer, Cracking the PM interview, Sigma/PlaceCom prep material. Group study in 3-4 different case groups to get varied perspectives of solving problems.

Q4. Any tips/suggestions?

Ans : Be thorough with your resume. Be confident and cheerful. Think aloud and practice at least 3-4 prod man cases in groups, it helps in building confidence in the interview.